

San Fairy Ann Cycling Club Newsletter

July 2026

Creator Lorna Stafford

Welcome to this month's newsletter! It's been a lively few weeks, with members sharing updates from their latest adventures. The ride reports are rolling in, and the stunning photos might just have you thinking, "I should've been on that one!"

From Chainrings to Wedding Rings.



1 - Trevor and Amanda. Club Members since 2022.

Everyone at San Fairy Ann wishes the happy couple a lifetime of love, laughter, and wonderful adventures, on and off the bike.

Ride to the Tour 2026. Two Bikes, Ten Countries, and One Incredible Adventure. And then there was one!



2 - Jeremy Roth and Mike Cross.



3 - Definitely beer time.



4 - Basilica Sagrada Familia



5 - Jeremy Roth



6 - Well deserved, we think!



7 - Jeremy Roth and Mike Cross

Ride to the Tour 2026. Two Bikes, Ten Countries, and One Incredible Adventure. by Jeremy Roth.

There are cycling holidays.....and then there are adventures.

On 23 June, Mike Cross and I rolled out of Paddock Wood with one simple objective: to ride our bikes all the way to the Tour de France.

No support vehicle. No luggage transfer. Just two bikes, a carefully planned route, and a determination to reach Barcelona entirely under our own power before continuing to the Costa Blanca.

By the time we finished, we'd ridden more than 2,700 kilometres, climbed over 57,000 feet, crossed 10 countries, and created memories that will stay with us forever.

Storms, Sunshine and the First Miles

The journey began exactly as you'd expect from a British summer, with thunderstorms. Barry kindly escorted us to Dover through torrential rain before we boarded the ferry to Dunkirk. Looking back from the deck as England disappeared over the horizon, the enormity of what lay ahead finally hit home. This wasn't another club ride. We were actually cycling to the Tour de France.

Within hours, everything changed. The rain vanished, and temperatures soared above 33°C, eventually reaching almost 47°C on several days. Suddenly, every ride became less about distance and more about surviving the relentless heat.

Hydration became an obsession. Aldi supermarkets turned into air-conditioned sanctuaries, village fountains became treasured discoveries, and more than one kind stranger appeared with a garden hose or a refill of cold water at exactly the right moment. Europe's cycle infrastructure proved exceptional — but nothing was quite as welcome as an ice cream after 140 miles in searing heat.

Across Europe and Into the Alps

The route itself was spectacular: Belgian cycle highways, peaceful riverside paths, converted railway lines stretching for miles through forests, bustling cities, sleepy villages and, eventually, the mighty Alps.

Crossing beneath the River Scheldt in Antwerp through a huge underground cycle tunnel was unforgettable. Arriving in Switzerland and seeing the mountains rise on the horizon brought a mix of excitement and apprehension.

The Alps did not disappoint.

The legendary Gotthard Pass was everything we'd imagined: endless hairpins, towering peaks and breathtaking scenery. It was also brutally hard. Steep gradients, soaring temperatures and long days in the saddle pushed us to our limits. There were moments when simply turning the pedals felt like an achievement.

Setbacks and a Difficult Decision

As with any adventure, things didn't always go to plan. There were punctures, navigation mistakes, hotels without air conditioning and roads that were little more than rocky tracks. But the biggest setback came after crossing the Alps.

After days of consecutive long rides and countless hours on the handlebars, Mike developed Handlebar Palsy, also known as Cyclist's Palsy, caused by prolonged pressure on the nerves in

the hands. The numbness and pain worsened, and after careful consideration he made the sensible decision to fly home from Nice rather than risk permanent damage.

That left me to continue the journey alone.

The Mistral: A Final Test

If I thought the hardest days were behind me, I couldn't have been more wrong.

Southern France had one final challenge waiting: the infamous Mistral. For almost 300 miles through Provence, I battled relentless headwinds of around 30 mph. Even on slight descents, it felt as though someone was pushing me backwards. Progress became painfully slow; every kilometre had to be earned, and mentally it proved to be the toughest part of the entire expedition.

There were moments of frustration, doubt, and times when the finish felt impossibly far away. But adventures aren't defined by the days when everything goes perfectly — they're defined by how you respond when they don't.

No One Rides Alone

One thing this journey reinforced was that, although only one person is turning the pedals, no one completes an adventure like this alone.

Every day I received messages of encouragement from family, friends and fellow club members. Those simple check-ins and words of support gave me a real lift, especially on the toughest days when the heat, headwinds and fatigue were taking their toll.

Above all, none of this would have been possible without the unwavering support of my partner. From the moment this adventure was just an idea, she believed I could do it. Her daily messages, encouragement, and constant belief in me gave me the strength to keep going — especially after Mike had flown home and I faced the final stages alone.

Although I crossed the finish line by myself, this adventure was never mine alone. It belonged to everyone who supported, encouraged, and believed in me from the first mile to the last.

The Real Story

The statistics are impressive, but they don't tell the story.

The story is the laughter after another wrong turn. The promise of a cold beer to get through the final 30 kilometres. The relief of finding another village fountain. The conversations over breakfast before another long day on the road. The encouragement from strangers shouting from passing vans. The emotion of watching England disappear from the ferry. The first sight of the Alps rising in the distance. And finally, the satisfaction of reaching Barcelona — and then continuing all the way to Albir, knowing every mile had been earned.

Most people experience the Tour de France from the roadside or on television.

We arrived there having ridden every mile from Kent.

It was never about speed. It was about adventure. Friendship. Resilience. And proving that ordinary cyclists can achieve extraordinary things with enough planning, determination and a willingness to embrace the unexpected.

Would I do it again?

Without hesitation.

Because once you've experienced Europe from the saddle of a bicycle, it has a way of calling you back.

Sun, Sweat and 980 Miles: The Tour Journey You'll Want to Read Santander–Dieppe – June, July 2026. by Steve Hargreaves.



8 - Packed Up



9 - The overall route



Ride to the Tour 2026 — A Taste of the Journey

Two bikes and almost a thousand miles: this year's Tour adventure was nothing short of extraordinary. Split into three distinct legs, the route carried us from the Spanish coast all the way back to Dieppe, with scenery, challenges and unforgettable moments at every turn.

Leg A — Santander to Bordeaux

Hugging the coastline of northern Spain and then France, Leg A delivered 360 miles and 5,600m of climbing over eight days. From St Sebastian to Biarritz and Bayonne, the weather was kind, the campsites welcoming, and the landscapes spectacular.

Leg B — Bordeaux to Beaugency

After a rest day in Bordeaux, we headed north through the beautiful Charente region and along the river Vienne. Seven riding days, 340 miles and 3,900m of ascent brought us into the Loire Valley, including a stunning mirror-calm view of Blois.

Leg C — Beaugency to Dieppe

The final 240-mile stretch felt like the home straight. Much of it followed the famous Avenue Verte, and we were joined by a friend for the run into Dieppe, where we celebrated "mission accomplished". A green bench made entirely from bicycle parts — proudly declaring *VIVE LE VÉLO* — summed up the spirit of French cycling perfectly.

Heat, Hills and Hard Graft

The toughest challenge? The heat. Temperatures in southern France soared above 45°C, forcing early starts, endless water stops, cooling towels, supermarket hideouts and even the occasional retreat under a tree until the air eased. But the rewards were immense: courteous drivers, beautiful back roads, unexpected cafés, quiet markets, and the simple rhythm of touring life.

By the Numbers

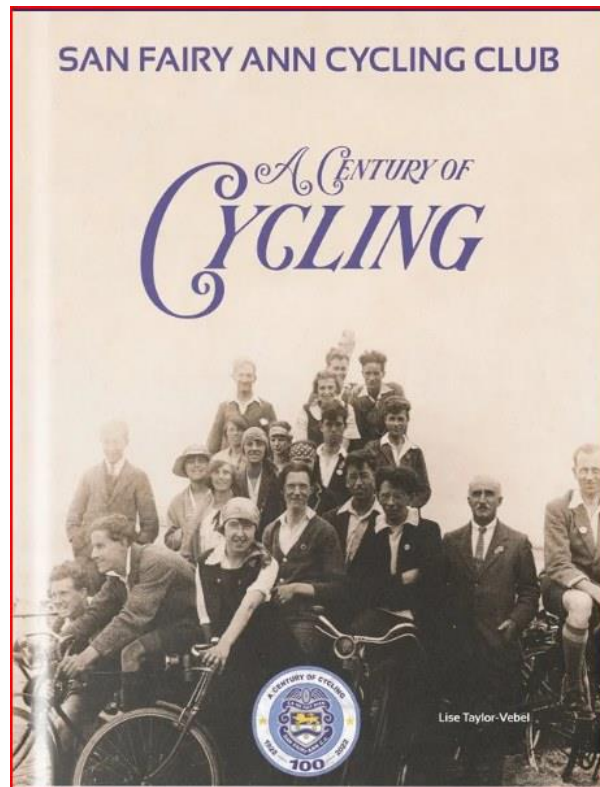
Total distance: 980 miles **Total ascent:** ~12,000m **Average day:** ~50 miles **Max speed:** 35mph **Cost:** ~£300 ferries + ~£40/day camping/food **Bike & kit:** Genesis Tour de Fer, Schwalbe Marathon tyres (zero punctures!), Ortlieb panniers, Vango tent — and a Helinox chair that proved surprisingly essential.

Why It Matters

Cycle touring is tough — heavy bikes, long climbs, unpredictable weather — but it's also profoundly rewarding. A month spent outdoors, living simply, seeing Europe at human speed. It's settling, re-setting, and unforgettable.

What next? Who knows — but the road has a way of calling you back. For the full article, [click here](#):

So... Why San Fairy Ann?



10 - [Buy The Book! HERE](#)

Quite often when we're out and about, someone will stop us to ask about the Club's unusual name. The full history is on the San [Fairy Ann website](#), and if you're really keen, **Lise Taylor-Vebel** even wrote a whole book about us, but here's the potted version.

The San Fairy Ann Cycling Club was founded on 22 March 1922 at the Anchor Inn in Yalding, with two simple aims: to enjoy club cycling and to appreciate the countryside. The name "San Fairy Ann" comes from the British soldiers' mangled version of the French phrase *ça ne fait rien*, meaning "**it doesn't matter**". The pronunciation was, of course, terrible, but the spirit was perfect.

It captured the carefree attitude of riders who loved cycling in all its forms, whatever the weather and wherever the road took them.

The name stuck.

And we still love it.

The Loop of Flanders trip - what a load of Cobbles! by Jill Edmans



11 - Jill Edmans



12 - [Commonwealth War Graves](#)



13 - *Menin Gate Memorial to the Missing.*



14 - [Brothers in Arms Memorial.](#)





15 - Jill, Emma, Steve & Geoff.



16 - Jill & Emma



17 - Jill



18 - Geoff



19 - Jill

And a tale of 5 cities, poignant WW war cemeteries, Roubaix velodrome, rolling Belgian countryside, stunning Dutch coasts and so much more (like great hotels & restaurants, excellent beer, ice cream and hot chocolate!)

A real adventure and just an easy hop across the channel. One of Sporta Sam's trips, supported by San Fairy Ann's very own Belgian Buns - Emma, Geoff, Steve & me.

We kicked off in Lille in the early afternoon with a little bit of suburban cycling on very decent cycle paths before arriving at the Roubaix Velodrome, where we did a few laps of the famous velodrome (some more adventurously than others!).

From Roubaix Velodrome, we headed east towards Oudenaarde, and then things got spicier. At 42 km we hit the famous cobbles of the Oude Kwaremont. There is no more famous climb in Belgian cycling, and whilst the initial ramps are testing, it is the length of the secteur that makes it tricky at 2km long. Thereafter, we hit the Paterberg at 47km - it is also a demanding climb, but does not last long! We then headed off via the Mariaborestraat and a final lump before crossing the river and getting to our hotel - where naturally we celebrated our conquest of the cobbles (and England's eventual triumph over Congo) with a most excellent Kwaremont beer!

Day 2 saw a lumpy start, but with a chilled finish. Initially very similar to the end of yesterday, but this route paid tribute to the Old Tour of Flanders. The first test was the Tainenberg (also known as the Boonenberg after the exploits of Tom Boonen, who launched numerous winning moves on this hill). Thereafter we headed in increasing rain towards the town of Geraardsbergen, which is famous for the Muur - a cobbled climb with a church at its summit which is synonymous with cycling in the region.

After the café break we headed off up the cobbles (the rain added a little piquancy, to put it mildly) and were thrilled to bump into the Lion of Flanders, Johan Museeuw, at the top! However, our enthusiasm was dented upon our return when we googled his history; whilst we had been a little dopey, it's all relative.

As the afternoon wore on, the rain stopped, and we wound our way through the lovely Flemish countryside towards the beautiful city of Ghent. Super hotel and a plethora of great restaurants to choose from. And Steve advised us that, in no circumstances, does he ever drink red wine...

Day 3 was our flat ride day, with a chocolate-box finish. From Ghent, we headed northeast and crossed into Holland towards the coast at Breskens. This route was flat and quiet, with beautiful canal paths and an increasing number of WW1/2 memorials. This region has a very interesting history, and whilst we had crossed a national border, the language remains the same, and the history is shared.

The port town of Breskens was flattened in WW2 as it was so important to Allied and Axis forces controlling the River Scheldt. And we could not resist the tranquil setting of Groede with its central church, pond - and bar. A most relaxing hour ensued with beer and ice creams to die for.

Once we hit the coast we headed west, which was tricky in the strong prevailing wind, and it was all I could do to hang on to Emma's coat tails along the glorious (and spotlessly clean) stretch of sand.

From the coast we headed south towards Brugge, our destination for that evening being the curious & rather delightful Velotel. A magical night (which seemed to involve eating lots of ribs) in the wonderful city of Brugge ensued.

Day 4 was a big, beautiful & sobering day - and my favourite; it had everything.

It combined stunning cycling with incredible history. From Brugge we wound our way south-east on quiet country lanes. The war memorials and cemeteries became more numerous as we headed south, with our major destination being Tyne Cot cemetery, shortly after the town of Passchendaele.

Tyne Cot is the largest cemetery managed by the Commonwealth War Graves Commission (CWGC) for any war. It is the final resting place/memorial for nearly 47000 soldiers from the United Kingdom, Australia, Canada, New Zealand, and South Africa. It has an aura all of its

own, and you don't have to be an historian to be affected by all it represents. Many more poignant monuments, statues, and cemeteries lined our onward journey, including the Black Watch and the extremely moving Brothers in Arms memorial (the latter including the Dire Straits anti-war song among its tributes).

And then - a really epic moment as we rode through the Menin Gate into Ypres; such an historic and beautiful city and perfect for lunch before our next challenge - our final cobbled ride up the Kemmelberg. This berg also has an incredible history, changing hands multiple times throughout the world wars, and it's now the focal point of the Gent Wevelgem spring classic. It was warm by then, and we already had a lot of miles in our legs - but everyone smashed it, and indeed Steve was quite vociferous at the top; I think he must have picked up a bit of Flemish along the way, but what he was actually saying may not bear close scrutiny.

The last hill at 80km was the infamous Messine Ridge, home to devastating blasts during 1915 following the tunnelling by British troops. It was also the site of the Christmas truce in 1914 where opposing forces sang Christmas carols across No Man's Land. It was then just a short ride back to Lille to our final hotel stop, with a rather raucous al fresco dinner to finish (can only have been down to the football on the big screen).

Day 5 sadly meant heading home, but Emma, Geoff & I had a little spare time in the morning, so we said a fond farewell to Sam, Steve & the others in our group, then headed into the majestic city of Lille for a farewell coffee (or hot chocolate, of course).

We really packed so much into this superb short trip - it was so accessible, so well managed and best of all, we had an absolute blast!

Jill Edmans

San Fairy Ann Cycling Club Bench, Millennium Park, Maidstone



20 - The bench funded by San Fairy Ann

Club President **Richard Valentine** and his wife Pat attended the celebration on the club's behalf, joining others for refreshments and afternoon tea.

This July marks the park's **Silver Anniversary**, celebrated with a **free concert on 18 July in Whatman Park**. Organisers are currently searching for individuals named on plaques or whose handprints were featured in the park's original display 25 years ago.

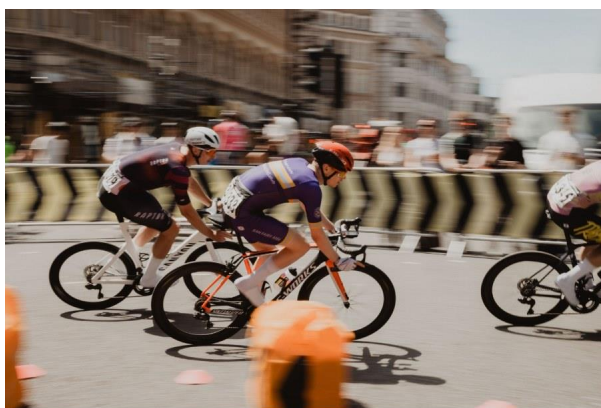
Race Team Update: The Latest News from the SFA Race Team. by Jonathan Leeson, Race Director.



21 - *Dave Harris*



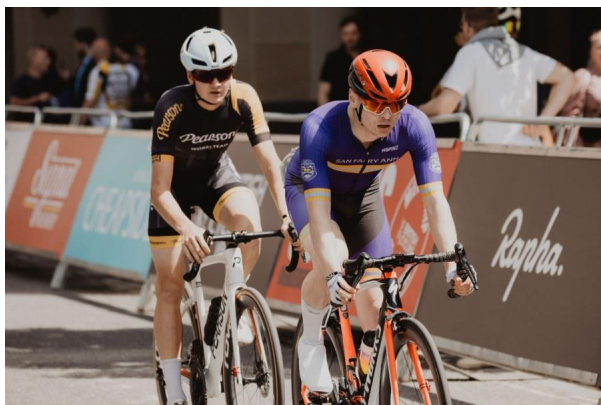
22 - *Rueban, Luis, Tommy.*



23 - Reuban – Nocturne London Event.



24 - Tommy– Nocturne London Event.



25 - Reuban – Nocturne London Event.

The Road Racing Calendar is in full swing, and the momentum is building. With all six CycloPark Crits in the Park races now wrapped up, the team has delivered some superb results — **David Harris' victory** in the final round and **Reuben Davey kicking things off with a strong 3rd place** in the opener.

So far this season, our riders have lined up for **over 25 races**, plus the club TTs, and have earned **two wins and seven podiums** along the way. The racing has been committed, competitive and great to watch. Massive congratulations to **Reuban, David, Tommy, Louis, Andy, Martin, Dave R and Tibor** for flying the San Fairy Ann Racing colours.

If you've ever thought about giving racing a go, now's the perfect time; drop me a message or join us at the TTs and upcoming events.

A special shout-out to our domestiques who marshalled at two CycloPark rounds. The feedback was brilliant, with Sarah Leeson summing it up perfectly: *"Marvelous way of seeing racing first hand."*

Jonathan Leeson – Race Director.

SFA Race Report.

This year, the SFA racing squad has raced in Hampshire and Essex, around the Bank of England at the City of London Nocturne races, at the Olympic Village, the classic 'ladies mile' course in Kent, and, of course, CycloPark. It's been a brilliant first season for a brand new team, and especially so for Andy, Louis and Tibor who are brand new to racing! San Fairy Ann is firmly back on the competitive scene and a force to be reckoned with, as proven after our decisive 3-up TTT wins over our local rivals.

At the start line of a local road race early this year, a seasoned marshal remarked of my team skinsuit, *'that's a kit I haven't seen in a long time'* - no longer! We are very grateful to Jonathan for bringing us together as a squad and supporting us throughout, and to Kevin for his advice and encouragement. It has been a fantastic experience to race as part of a team, and I have loved navigating the swirling road-race peloton with friends in purple by my side. Bike racing is a fantastic sport, but is elevated to another level when done as a team and with the support of a club.

By Tom Walden-Smith.

VTTA 50-Mile Time Trial – 5 July By Reuban Davey.





26 - Autumn Richardson.





VTTA 50-Mile Time Trial – 5 July

San Fairy Ann riders were out in force for Kent's only 50-mile time trial, held on the Q50/11 course. Despite its reputation for tight corners and busy junctions, the team delivered an excellent set of results.

Results

- **Reuban Davey – 1:52:11 (PB)** 2nd place overall behind Nic Fennell, averaging **26.7 mph**. A superb ride and a well-earned personal best.
- **Andy Cairns – 2:04:50** Riding a road bike, Andy placed **3rd in the road bike category** and **20th overall**.
- **Autumn Richardson – 3:12:37** In her longest ride ever, and only **six weeks into cycling**, Autumn won **Fastest Non-Veteran Female**. A fantastic achievement.
- **Mark Vowells – 2:19:41 (Tricycle)** Mark secured the **Stan Spelling Memorial Shield**, run alongside the main event.

Photos

[Images from the day can be viewed here: VTTA 50 TT · Jul 5–24 app.goo.gl](#)

KCA 3-Up Team Time Trial – 28 June

SFA riders also took part in the KCA 3-Up TTT on the Ham Street Bypass, fielding two road-bike-only teams.

Team Results

- **Reuban Davey, Martin Kober & Tom Rowing-Dent** 2nd place in **32:06**, beating the top K20 team by **22 seconds**.
- **Dave Richards, David Harris & Louis Turner** 4th place in **33:03**, finishing **1 minute 24 seconds** ahead of the second K20 squad.

A strong showing across the board, with SFA coming out on top against local rivals K20.

Solo Riders

- **David Prom** – **36:41**
- **Mark Vowells (Tricycle)** – **38:00**
- **Autumn Richardson** – **51:27**

Sun, Sweat and Summit Curves: San Fairy Ann CC Takes on Annecy. By the SFACC Away Team





Thirteen San Fairy Ann members headed to the French Alps at the end of May for a week of spectacular riding based in Manigod, high on the Col de la Croix Fry. What awaited us was an unforgettable mix of iconic climbs, stunning scenery, excellent food, and an unexpected late-spring heatwave that made every ascent even more memorable.

Our base at Chalet Caramel couldn't have been better. Every ride began and ended with mountain views, fresh croissants, and, after some long days in the saddle, welcome relief in the pool and jacuzzi. Evenings were spent enjoying home-cooked meals and reliving the day's adventures on the balcony overlooking the valley.

The Riding

The week featured some of the best-known climbs around Lake Annecy and beyond.

We opened with the **Col de la Forclaz**, climbing above the lake to watch paragliders launch while enjoying spectacular views before descending to a lakeside café.

The following days took us over the **Col des Aravis**, through the beautiful roads around **La Clusaz** and **Entremont**, and on to the legendary **Semnoz**, a climb many tackled for the first time. Long alpine descents, quiet mountain roads and sweeping bends made every ride as rewarding as the climbs themselves.

Even our so-called 'rest day' involved plenty of riding, while two members took to the skies with tandem paragliders over Lake Annecy.

A Grand Finale

Our final ride was the toughest and arguably the most memorable: the magnificent **Cornet de Roselend** and **Col du Pré**. Snow still lined the upper slopes as we climbed to over 1,900 metres, then descended past turquoise reservoirs and breathtaking Alpine scenery, with Mont Blanc visible in the distance.

By the Numbers

- **13 riders**

- **6 days of riding**
- Around **535 km** covered
- Over **11,000 metres** of climbing
- Temperatures well into the **30°Cs**

The climbs were challenging, the heat relentless, but the scenery, camaraderie and sense of achievement made it a week none of us will forget.

A huge thank you to everyone who helped organise another fantastic San Fairy Ann cycling adventure. Here's to the next trip! For the [full article and photos, click here:](#)

20 June 2026 - John goes it alone! By John Bosley.



27 - John & Colin.



28 - John & Colin.



29 - John & Colin.



30 - John Bosley.

A good friend, Catriona, offered to support Kate and me to attempt 'Chase the Sun'. That's the ride that starts in Minster-on-Sea at sunrise on the longest day, and the aim is to reach Weston-super-Mare (335km) before sunset.

Then Kate got injured, and I was inadvertently set up to give it a go on my half bike! Riding with a friend, Colin, who had completed the event last year and vowed, "never again".

We diligently followed the suggested training plan (give or take a few disrupted weeks) and were good to go (whatever that means).

The route is great; it touches London but not central London, and uses many reasonably quiet, flat or rolling roads, though there are some hills!

At halfway we were on our schedule of about 25kph. Having done about 100 miles, I was feeling pretty confident, Colin, though he said he was finding it a challenge. We pushed on, though, with enough time to take a gentler pace, and when I could, I would be in front to help Colin out. Occasionally I would inadvertently up the pace and realise that it wasn't Colin behind me after a while, so I'd slow a little to get him back on my wheel.

Things got a little more challenging with hills to climb up the Mendips, but we remained on target.

We reached WSM at about 9 pm. What an amazing achievement; the reward was being there to see a beautiful sunset. But they also gave us a nice medal 🏅

The next day was a rest day, then my cycling buddy, David, joined me and we spent a few fun days cycling back to Kent. It wasn't without its adventures!

Fairies Support Race for Life.



31 - Mike, Theresa.



32 - Theresa.



33 - Mike, Theresa, and Steve.

The annual Race for Life took place in Maidstone earlier this month, with hundreds of participants gathering in Mote Park to raise money for a cause that continues to touch so many lives.

The event, which offers both 5K and 10K distances, starts and finishes on the grass in Mote Park. The 10K race got underway at 10:00 am, followed by the 5K an hour later, as runners, joggers and walkers of all abilities came together to support Cancer Research UK.

Once again, San Fairy Ann members were there to help. Mike Lambourne from E Group, Theresa Hammond from D Group and Steve Farndon volunteered their time to act as tail

riders, ensuring everyone completed the course safely and that no participant was left behind.

A big thank you to Mike, Theresa and Steve for giving up their time to support such a worthwhile event. Your efforts helped make the day a success and demonstrated the community spirit that San Fairy Ann is proud to be part of.

And a Thank You from the organisers: So far, with sponsorship still coming in, we are at an amazing £480,000!!!! All going towards vital research. Please please know what a huge difference you all made and that the event wouldn't have taken place without your support.

Save the Dates for 2026

[Book Now!](#)

- 6th September - Autumn Audax - Chart Sutton Village Hall. [Book Now!](#)

Welcome to SFA.

JIM YOUNG

GAVIN HALES

JAMES TAYLOR

Member Contributions

Here's a version that keeps the friendly tone while adding the practical requests:

A Reminder!

This newsletter is at its best when it includes **your** stories, not just mine.

If you've:



Been on a club ride



Discovered a great café (or a terrible one...)



Found a cracking route



Taken some photos worth sharing

...then please send it in!

It doesn't have to be polished or poetic—a few lines are plenty. I can tidy it up if needed (that's my superpower).

One small favour: please send **the text and photos as separate files**, rather than as a finished page or layout. It makes it much easier for me to copy, edit and fit everything into the newsletter.

Also, please tell me **who's in the photos**, using **first and last names**, so I can give everyone the credit they deserve.

If you rode it, ate it, broke it, fixed it, or laughed about it afterwards, we'd love to hear about it.

Sharing is caring... and it saves me from having to make things up. 😊

Please send your articles and photos to Lorna via WhatsApp or email at membership@sanfairyanncc.co.uk.

Club Contacts

Richard Valentine - President 07505 262465

Duncan Edwards - Chair 07402 549927

Jonathan Engwell - Finance 07801 014877

Jonathan Leeson - Information Technology & Racing Team Lead - 07713 318186

Lorna Stafford - Membership & Events 07790 017482

Stephen Harmer - Events/Club Trips 07539 324565

Linton Schwarz - Club Kit 07901 851707

Emma Tuffey Director Of Club Runs & Events - 07976 262260

Jenny Burton - Club Welfare Officer - 07780 678201

Bob Watts - Sportives & Audax - bobwatts999@gmail.com

Veronica Harmer - Club Secretary & Events - 07910 265061

Tony Palmer - Training & Safety - 07786 393838